

Service Blueprint

Map front-stage and back-stage of a service

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PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

A Service Blueprint maps a service end-to-end across layers: customer actions, **front-stage** (visible) employee actions, **back-stage** (invisible) actions, and supporting processes, separated by a 'line of visibility'. It reveals how the whole system must work to deliver the customer experience.

WHO DEVELOPED IT

Introduced by banking executive G. Lynn Shostack in the *Harvard Business Review* in 1984.

WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Services are intangible and cross many functions, so failures fall between the cracks. Blueprinting makes the invisible back-stage explicit and assigns responsibility.

HOW IT IS USED

Lay out customer steps, then map the front- and back-stage actions and systems that support each, marking fail points and hand-offs to redesign.

WHEN IT IS USED

Designing or fixing services and multi-touchpoint experiences, in prototyping and implementation.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

Service designers, operations managers and CX teams.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO PRIOR PRACTICE

It extends prototyping from the **artefact to the whole delivery system**, connecting front-stage experience to back-stage operations.

FIGURE 1 · PROCESS VIEW

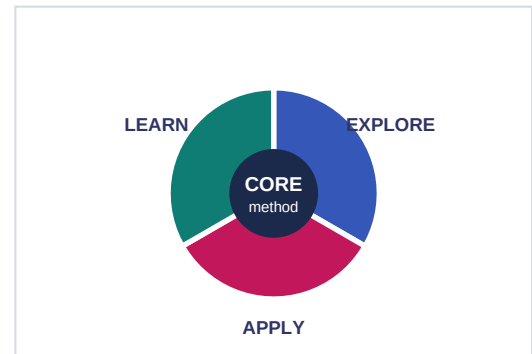


Figure 1. Service Blueprint framed as a continuous, iterative method — explore, apply and learn cycle back through the work rather than run once.

RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Customer Journey Map *Slibrary 5*

Minimum Viable Product (MVP) *Slibrary 8*

Implementation Roadmap *Slibrary 10*

SOURCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Shostack, G.L. (1984) 'Designing Services That Deliver', *Harvard Business Review*, 62(1), pp. 133–139.

Stickdorn, M. and Schneider, J. (2011) *This Is Service Design Thinking*. Amsterdam: BIS Publishers.